

A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR REMOTE PROFESSIONALS

The Remote VA Toolkit

16 core responsibilities, the modern tools virtual assistants use for each one, and a real-world sample of the work.

16

Responsibility areas

90+

Tool picks, by purpose

16

Work samples

Tools reviewed September 2026

HOW TO USE THIS DECK

16 areas, two slides each: tools, then a sample

01 Data Management	02 Calendar Management	03 Email Management	04 Operations Reports
05 Inventory Management	06 Travel Arrangements	07 Booking Management	08 Records and Documentation
09 Reports and Presentations	10 Digital Files Organization	11 Task and Project Management	12 AI Management
13 Content and Design	14 SEO	15 Research and Info Gathering	16 Remote Team Communication

Jump to any area from the outline panel. Each area opens with its tools, followed by a sample of the finished work.

Six tool categories every remote VA uses daily



Workspace

Google Workspace or Microsoft 365: email, calendar, docs, sheets, slides



Communication

Slack or Microsoft Teams for chat, Zoom or Google Meet for calls, Loom for video updates



Tasks

Asana, ClickUp, Trello, Monday.com or Notion to track every request to done



Files

Google Drive, OneDrive or Dropbox with a clear folder and naming system



AI assistants

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot to draft, summarize and research faster



Security

1Password or Bitwarden to share logins safely, plus two-step verification on every account

A TYPICAL DAY

How the 16 areas fit into one working day

8:00

Inbox and calendar

Triage email, confirm today's meetings, flag urgent items

9:30

Team check-in

Post priorities in Slack, update the task board

10:00

Deep work

Data entry, bookings, travel, research, content

2:00

Reports and files

Update trackers, file documents, prepare reports

4:30

End-of-day report

Done, in progress, blockers, plan for tomorrow

The pattern: **communicate first, focus in the middle, report at the end.** Clients trust a VA they never have to chase.

Data Management

Keeping client data accurate, organized and easy to find.

WHAT YOU DO

- Enter data from forms, emails and invoices
- Clean duplicates, typos and mixed formats
- Keep the CRM and contact lists current
- Build trackers with dropdowns and checks
- Protect sensitive data and keep backups

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Google Sheets	Shared sheets, formulas, Gemini help
Microsoft Excel	Power Query cleanup, Copilot analysis
Airtable	Spreadsheet-database with forms and views
HubSpot CRM	Free CRM for contacts, deals, follow-ups
Zapier / Make	Move data between apps automatically
Google Forms	Collect clean data at the source

Pro tip: use dropdowns and data validation so bad data never gets in, instead of fixing it later.

A client database after cleanup

Clients · Google Sheets · 248 rows

Filter: Active

ID	Client	Email	Status	Updated
C-1042	Lopez Dental	ana@lopezdental.co	Active	09/22/26
C-1043	North Bay Realty	ops@northbay.co	Active	09/24/26
C-1044	Grace Bakery	hello@gracebakes.co	Paused	09/18/26
C-1045	Summit HVAC	info@summithvac.co	Active	09/26/26
C-1046	Blue Pine Legal	Missing	Check	09/27/26

18 duplicates merged

6 missing emails flagged

Dates unified

WHY IT WORKS

- Every record has a unique ID
- Status comes from a dropdown, never typed
- Gaps are flagged, not guessed
- A cleanup log shows what changed

BUILT WITH

Google Sheets, data validation, conditional formatting, remove duplicates

Calendar Management

Guarding the client’s time so the right meetings happen at the right hours.

WHAT YOU DO

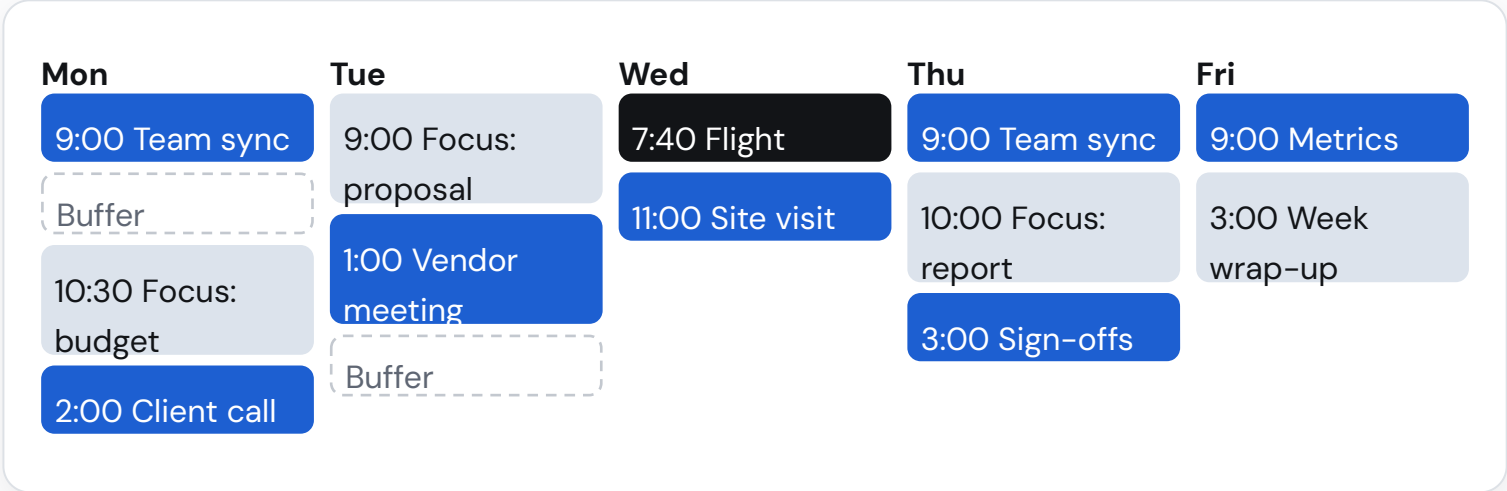
- Schedule meetings across time zones
- Protect focus time and add buffers
- Send invites with agenda and link
- Handle reschedules and conflicts
- Share a weekly calendar preview

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Google Calendar	Shared calendars, booking pages
Outlook Calendar	Microsoft 365 teams, Scheduling Assistant
Calendly	Booking links with rules and reminders
Reclaim.ai	AI time blocking that protects focus time
Motion	AI that plans tasks into the calendar
World Time Buddy	Compare time zones at a glance

Pro tip: always write the time zone in every invite and message, for example 9:00 AM EST / 10:00 PM PHT.

A protected executive week



LEGEND

- **Blue:** meetings
- **Gray:** protected focus time
- **Black:** travel
- Dashed: 15-minute buffer

WHY IT WORKS

Focus time is booked like a meeting, calls never run back to back, and Friday previews next week.

Email Management

A clear, answered inbox where nothing important slips through.

WHAT YOU DO

- Sort mail with labels, folders and filters
- Reply fast using saved templates
- Flag urgent items and track follow-ups
- Unsubscribe and archive the clutter
- Send the client a daily inbox summary

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Gmail + Gemini	Labels, templates, AI summaries and drafts
Outlook + Copilot	Rules, Focused Inbox, AI drafting
Superhuman	Fast AI inbox for heavy email users
SaneBox	Moves low-priority mail out of the way
Front / Help Scout	Shared team inboxes with assignments
Grammarly	Tone, clarity and grammar checks

Pro tip: check email at set times, such as 8:30, 12:30 and 4:30, instead of all day. Replies get faster, not slower.

A label system and a reply template

LABELS

01 Action

Reply today

02 Waiting

Sent, awaiting reply

03 Read later

Newsletters

04 Reference

Keep, no action

05 Receipts

Invoices, bookings

Numbers keep labels in priority order.

TEMPLATE: MEETING REQUEST

Subject: **Re: Meeting with [Name]**

Hi [Name],

Thank you for reaching out. [Client] is available on [\[Tue, Oct 6 at 10:00 AM EST\]](#) or [\[Wed, Oct 7 at 2:00 PM EST\]](#). Which works best for you? I will send the invite once you confirm.

Best regards,

[Your name], Assistant to [Client]

Operations Reports

Turning daily activity into numbers a manager can act on.

WHAT YOU DO

- Pull data from sales, support and orders
- Track KPIs against weekly targets
- Keep a live dashboard up to date
- Summarize wins, issues and next steps
- Send reports on a fixed schedule

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Sheets / Excel	Source data, formulas, pivot tables
Looker Studio	Free live dashboards from Google data
Power BI	Dashboards for Microsoft-based teams
Zoho Analytics	KPI dashboards across many apps
Databox	Auto-updating KPI scorecards
Claude / ChatGPT	Summarize trends, then check the math

Pro tip: lead with three headline numbers and one sentence. Put the detailed tables after.

A weekly operations report

Weekly Operations Report · Sep 21 to 27

Prepared Monday, 9:00 AM

Orders shipped

1,240

Up 4% vs last week

On-time delivery

96%

Target 95%, met

Tickets resolved

312

Same as last week

First reply time

2.1 hrs

Target 2 hrs, missed

Wins

Record week for orders. New courier cut late deliveries in half.

Issues

Reply time slipped on Friday when two agents were out.

Next steps

Add weekend cover, owner: Support Lead, due Oct 2.

Inventory Management

Knowing what is in stock, what is running low, and what to reorder.

WHAT YOU DO

- Track stock levels and locations
- Set reorder points and low-stock alerts
- Log items in, out and returned
- Reconcile physical counts with records
- Prepare purchase orders for suppliers

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Zoho Inventory	Stock, orders and shipping, free plan
Sortly	Mobile tracking with barcodes and QR
Shopify / Square	Stock synced with online or store sales
QuickBooks	Links stock value to accounting
Katana	Inventory for small manufacturers
Google Sheets	Simple tracker for small stock lists

Pro tip: reorder point = daily usage × supplier lead time + safety stock. Set it once per item.

A stock tracker with reorder alerts

Stock count · Warehouse A · Sep 28

SKU	Item	On hand	Reorder at	Status
PK-101	Shipping box, small	420	150	OK
PK-102	Shipping box, large	95	120	Reorder
LB-210	Thermal labels	1,800	500	OK
TP-330	Packing tape	36	60	Reorder
BW-405	Bubble wrap roll	24	20	Low soon

2 items to reorder · PO draft sent to supplier for approval

WHY IT WORKS

- Status is a formula, so it updates on its own
- Reorder rows are highlighted and labeled
- Every count has a date and location

BUILT WITH

Google Sheets or Zoho Inventory, with an IF formula for status

Travel Arrangements

Planning trips so the traveler only has to show up.

WHAT YOU DO

- Compare and book flights, hotels, cars
- Build a day-by-day itinerary
- Check passports, visas and entry forms
- Track the budget and collect receipts
- Rebook fast when plans change

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Google Flights	Compare fares and track price drops
Skyscanner / Kayak	Search fares across many airlines
Booking.com / Airbnb	Hotels and short-term stays
Triplt	Itinerary built from confirmation emails
Navan	Company travel booking and expenses
Google Maps	Routes, transfer times, nearby places

Pro tip: save every confirmation number in one place and share it with the traveler before they leave.

Day one of a business trip itinerary

Manila to Singapore · Day 1

5:30

Car pickup from home · driver texts on arrival

8:05

Flight to Singapore · seat 3A, conf. [ABC123]

12:30

Transfer to hotel · arrival hall, door 5

3:00

Hotel check-in · 3 nights, conf. [HTL-4481]

7:00

Welcome dinner with partners · table for 6

Budget: ₱72,390 of ₱80,000 used · Same time zone as Manila

Wed, Oct 14

WHY IT WORKS

- One screen per day, times first
- Confirmation numbers right where needed
- Pickup details prevent missed rides
- Budget shown at a glance

BUILT WITH

Google Docs or Triplt, plus a Sheets booking tracker

Booking Management

Filling the client’s schedule with confirmed appointments and fewer no-shows.

WHAT YOU DO

- Manage appointment and service bookings
- Send confirmations and reminders
- Handle reschedules, cancellations, no-shows
- Reserve venues, tables and event spots
- Keep a clean booking log

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Calendly	Meeting bookings with routing and reminders
Acuity Scheduling	Appointments with intake forms, payments
Cal.com	Open-source booking pages
SimplyBook.me	Booking for salons, clinics, services
OpenTable	Restaurant reservations
Eventbrite	Event registration and tickets

Pro tip: send two reminders, one day before and two hours before. It is the simplest way to cut no-shows.

A daily booking log for a clinic

Bookings · Thursday, Oct 8

Time	Client	Service	Status	Reminder
9:00	R. Santos	Consultation	Confirmed	Sent 2x
10:30	M. Cruz	Follow-up	Confirmed	Sent 2x
1:00	J. Reyes	Cleaning	Moved to Oct 9	Updated
2:30	A. Lim	Consultation	Pending	Sent 1x
4:00	K. Tan	Follow-up	No-show	Rebook offer

5 bookings · 1 moved · 1 no-show, rebooking email sent

WHY IT WORKS

- Every booking has a written status
- Reminders are tracked, not assumed
- No-shows get a same-day follow-up

BUILT WITH

Acuity or Calendly for bookings, Google Sheets for the log

Records and Documentation

Writing things down once so the whole team can find and follow them.

WHAT YOU DO

- Write SOPs and step-by-step guides
- Take and share meeting minutes
- File contracts, forms and receipts
- Collect e-signatures and track versions
- Control who can view or edit records

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Google Docs / Word	Documents with comments and history
Notion / Confluence	Team wikis and SOP libraries
Scribe / Tango	Auto step-by-step guides from clicks
DocuSign	E-signatures with an audit trail
Adobe Acrobat	PDFs, fillable forms, redaction
Fathom / Otter.ai	AI meeting notes and action items

Pro tip: if you do a task twice, write an SOP. The third time, anyone on the team can do it.

A one-page SOP

SOP-014 · Processing a new client invoice

v1.2 · Owner: Admin

Purpose: pay suppliers on time and keep records complete. Time: 10 minutes.

1. Save the invoice PDF to Finance / 2026 / Invoices.
2. Rename it: 2026-10-02_SupplierName_INV-0451.pdf.
3. Check amount and PO number against the order.
4. Log it in the Invoice Tracker with the due date.
5. Send to the approver using the approval template.
6. After payment, mark Paid and file the receipt.

EVERY SOP HAS

- An ID, version and owner
- Purpose and time needed
- Numbered steps, one action each
- Exact folder and file names

BUILT WITH

Notion or Google Docs, screenshots from Scribe

Reports and Presentations

Turning notes and numbers into slides people understand quickly.

WHAT YOU DO

- Outline the story before designing
- Build slides on the brand template
- Turn tables into clear charts
- Proofread every number and name
- Export PDF and write speaker notes

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
PowerPoint	Company decks, Copilot for first drafts
Google Slides	Shared decks the team edits together
Canva	Templates, brand kits, polished visuals
Gamma	AI first drafts of whole decks
Beautiful.ai	Slides that format themselves
Claude / ChatGPT	Outlines, summaries, speaker notes

Pro tip: write every slide title as the takeaway, for example “Sales grew 8% in Q3”, not just “Sales”.

A five-slide monthly review outline



Why it works: one idea per slide, numbers before detail, and it always ends with who does what by when.

Digital Files Organization

Any file found in under 30 seconds, by anyone on the team.

WHAT YOU DO

- Design a simple folder structure
- Apply one file naming rule everywhere
- Set sharing and access permissions
- Remove duplicates, archive old files
- Keep backups and store logins safely

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Google Drive	Shared drives, search, version history
OneDrive / SharePoint	Files for Microsoft 365 teams
Dropbox	Large files and client file requests
Box	Secure storage for regulated work
1Password / Bitwarden	Share logins without sending passwords
Adobe Acrobat	Merge, compress and protect PDFs

Pro tip: start file names with the date, YYYY-MM-DD. Files then sort in order automatically.

A shared drive structure and naming rule

COMPANY DRIVE

01 Admin

02 Clients

Lopez Dental

Contracts · Invoices · Reports

03 Finance

2026 · Invoices, Receipts

04 Marketing

05 Templates and SOPs

99 Archive

NAMING RULE

Date_Client_Type_Version

2026-10-02_LopezDental_Contract_v02.pdf

2026-09-30_NorthBay_Report_v01.xlsx

- Numbered top folders stay in order
- Three levels deep at most
- Archive instead of delete

Task and Project Management

Every request tracked from “asked” to “done”, with an owner and a date.

WHAT YOU DO

- Turn requests into tasks with due dates
- Assign owners and set priorities
- Keep the board current every day
- Chase deadlines before they slip
- Run recurring checklists and weekly status

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Asana	Projects, timelines and dependencies
ClickUp	Tasks, docs and chat in one place
Trello	Simple Kanban boards
Monday.com	Visual workflows and dashboards
Notion	Task databases next to team docs
Todoist	Fast personal to-do lists

Pro tip: if a request arrives in chat or email, move it to the board right away. If it is not on the board, it does not exist.

A weekly task board

The task board is organized into four vertical columns, each representing a different stage of task completion. The 'To do' column has three tasks, 'In progress' has two, 'Waiting' has one, and 'Done' has four. Each task is represented by a white card with a blue border, containing a bold title and a subtitle with a due date and assignee.

To do · 3	In progress · 2	Waiting · 1	Done · 4
Book Singapore hotel Due Oct 5 · VA	September report Due Oct 2 · VA	Contract signature Sent Sep 29 · Client	Inbox cleanup
Update client list Due Oct 6 · VA	Invoice follow-ups Due Oct 3 · VA		Meeting notes, Sep 28
Draft newsletter Due Oct 8 · Marketing			Supplier call booked
			Drive folders renamed

AI Management

Using AI to work faster, while checking every output before it goes out.

WHAT YOU DO

- Draft, summarize and rewrite with AI
- Build a library of tested prompts
- Set up custom assistants for the client
- Automate repeat work with AI workflows
- Fact-check output and protect private data

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
ChatGPT	Drafting, custom GPTs, data analysis
Claude	Long documents, Projects, careful writing
Gemini	AI inside Gmail, Docs, Sheets; Gems
Microsoft Copilot	AI inside Outlook, Word, Excel, Teams
Perplexity	Quick answers with cited sources
Zapier / Make	AI steps inside automated workflows

Pro tip: never paste passwords, bank details or private client data into an AI tool the client has not approved.

A reusable prompt template

ROLE	You are an executive assistant for a logistics company.
TASK	Summarize the meeting notes below into a follow-up email.
CONTEXT	Audience: the client team. Tone: friendly, brief, professional.
FORMAT	3 key decisions, then action items with owner and due date. Under 150 words.
CHECK	List anything unclear in the notes instead of guessing.

[Paste meeting notes here]

WHY IT WORKS

- Same five parts every time
- Clear length and format
- The CHECK line stops made-up details
- Saved once, reused daily

WORKS IN

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot. Save it as a custom GPT, Project or Gem.

Content and Design

On-brand graphics, videos and posts, published on a steady schedule.

WHAT YOU DO

- Design social graphics and banners
- Edit short videos and reels
- Plan a monthly content calendar
- Write captions and schedule posts
- Keep fonts, colors and logos consistent

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Canva	Graphics, brand kits, AI design help
CapCut	Short videos, captions, reels
Adobe Express	Quick branded graphics and videos
Figma	Web and app mockups with designers
Buffer / Metricool	Schedule posts, track engagement
Grammarly	Clean, on-tone captions and copy

Pro tip: set up a brand kit first: logo, two fonts, three colors. Every design after that takes half the time.

One week of a content calendar

Content calendar · Week of Oct 5 · Home services brand

Day	Channel	Format	Topic	Status
Mon	Facebook	Graphic	AC warning signs	Scheduled
Tue	Instagram	Reel, 20s	Before and after repair	Scheduled
Wed	LinkedIn	Post	Meet the team	In review
Thu	Instagram	Carousel	Fall maintenance list	Designing
Fri	Facebook	Story post	Approved customer story	Drafting

WHY IT WORKS

- Mixed formats keep the feed fresh
- Status shows what needs attention
- Planned a week ahead, not daily

BUILT WITH

Notion or Google Sheets for the plan, Canva and CapCut to create, Buffer to schedule

SEO

Helping the right customers find the business on Google and in AI answers.

WHAT YOU DO

- Research keywords customers search for
- Update titles, meta descriptions, headings
- Monitor Search Console for errors
- Set up tracking and read Analytics
- Keep the Google Business Profile current

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Search Console	Clicks, indexing, sitemaps, site errors
Google Analytics 4	Visitors, sources, conversions
Tag Manager	Track clicks and forms without code
Semrush / Ahrefs	Keywords, competitors, AI visibility
Screaming Frog	Crawl a site for broken links, gaps
PageSpeed Insights	Page speed and Core Web Vitals

Pro tip: write clear answers to real customer questions. It helps both Google rankings and AI search tools (GEO).

A monthly SEO snapshot

SEO snapshot · September 2026 · Source: Google Search Console

vs August

Clicks 2,860 Up 12%	Impressions 74,300 Up 18%	Click-through rate 3.8% Down 0.2 pts	Avg. position 14.2 Up from 16.9
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Done this month

Rewrote 8 page titles and meta descriptions, fixed 3 broken links, resubmitted the sitemap.

Next month

Add FAQs to the top 3 service pages and improve mobile page speed.

Research and Information Gathering

Finding reliable answers fast, and showing where they came from.

WHAT YOU DO

- Compare vendors, products and prices
- Research competitors and markets
- Build lead and contact lists
- Fact-check claims against sources
- Summarize findings in a short brief

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Perplexity	Fast answers with linked sources
Deep research	Long reports in ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude
NotebookLM	Summarize and question your own files
Google Search	Operators like site: and filetype:
Sales Navigator	LinkedIn lead and company research
Google Scholar	Studies and reliable data sources

Pro tip: open and read every source an AI tool cites. AI can summarize a page wrong or link to one that does not say it.

A vendor comparison brief

Question: which payroll service fits a 12-person team?

Criteria	Vendor A	Vendor B	Vendor C
Monthly cost	[Price]	[Price]	[Price]
Local tax filing	Yes	Yes	No
Payslip app	Yes	No	Yes
Setup time	1 week	2 weeks	3 days
Fit	Best fit	Good	Missing tax

Sources: each vendor’s pricing page and 2 review sites, checked Sep 28

WHY IT WORKS

- Starts with the exact question
- Same criteria for every option
- Ends with a clear recommendation
- Sources and date are listed

BUILT WITH

Perplexity to find sources, Google Sheets for the table

Remote Team Communication

Keeping a team in different places and time zones in sync.

WHAT YOU DO

- Post daily updates and end-of-day reports
- Set up meetings, agendas and notes
- Share quick video walkthroughs
- Coordinate hand-offs across time zones
- Log hours and keep channels tidy

MODERN TOOLS

Tool	Use it for
Slack	Team channels, threads, huddles
Microsoft Teams	Chat and calls for Microsoft 365 teams
Zoom / Google Meet	Video meetings and screen sharing
Loom	Short recorded video updates
Fathom	AI meeting notes and summaries
Time Doctor / Toggl	Time tracking and timesheets

Pro tip: write updates so they make sense without a call. Async-first saves everyone’s time across time zones.

An end-of-day report in Slack



Alex, your VA #ops-updates · 5:02 PM

EOD report, Thursday Oct 8

Done: September report sent, 14 invoices logged, Singapore hotel booked

In progress: client list cleanup, 60% done, finish Friday noon

Blocked: contract still unsigned, reminder sent, may need a call

Tomorrow: newsletter draft, supplier call at 10:00 AM EST

WHY IT WORKS

- Same four headings every day
- Numbers show real progress
- Blockers are raised early
- Readable in 20 seconds

BUILT WITH

Slack or Teams, with a saved message template

Four rules for picking the right tool

1 Use what the client uses

Match their workspace before suggesting anything new.

2 Go deep on one per category

Mastering Asana beats knowing five task apps a little.

3 Start on the free plan

Most tools here have a free tier or trial. Upgrade when the work needs it.

4 Security comes first

Password manager, two-step verification, and only approved AI tools for client data.

WHERE TO START

Master email, calendar and tasks first. The other 13 build on them.

Pick one tool per area, practice with the samples in this deck, and add a new skill each month.